

L'ATELIER
de Joël Robuchon

MIAMI



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Nestled discreetly within Miami's Design District, amidst a plethora of luxury brand boutiques, this restaurant effortlessly absorbs the city's chic ambiance, further elevating the very essence of its brand. Much like the city itself, perpetually at the forefront of fashion, L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon presents a menu that evolves with the times. What may surprise patrons is the absence of Monsieur Robuchon's signature pièce de résistance, a deliberate deviation that adds an element of delightful unpredictability to the dining experience.

Considering that I have never experienced a complete tasting menu at any of L'Atelier de Joël Robuchon's locations, I decide to give it a chance by choosing the evolution menu. The menu commences with a familiar old mate — the signature foie gras royale. The warm foie gras custard is drenched in the essence of the old vine Maury wine, then capped with a rich parmesan foam.



In the small shot glass wafts a suave aroma with depth that immediately transports me onto a journey on the Orient Express. With each spoonful, the rich, unctuous foie gras sings in perfect harmony with the Maury wine essence. Reminiscent of a fine tawny port, the Maury wine essence reveals a resinous, condensed texture, carrying its sophisticated mellowness and aroma. The medley is further sublimated by the gorgeous parmesan cheese espuma, which offers a magical tangy brininess through its ethereal touch on the palate.

The familiar bread basket soon makes its rendezvous, with fewer varieties in this Miami venue yet maintaining its usual high quality. Within the basket, we discover mini baguettes, escargot croissants, and milk bread with comté cheese — all baked with finesse.



As the dinner gradually unfolds, the cuisine takes a swift turn towards innovative approaches. In the first appetizer, the chef presents the Norwegian king crab, a common French dish, in a highly unusual combination. The horseradish-seasoned vinaigrette not only serves to awaken the palate but also divulges a touch of earthy spiciness, distinguishing itself from the usual acidic light dressings. Further enveloping the king crab is a creamy cloud of compressed golden beets, a sauce that is both rich and airy, filled with subtle earthiness and strong hints of condensed sweetness.

The use of beets to enhance the flavor of crustaceans is not a common practice in traditional French cuisine, but this bold move proves to be utterly successful. The entire dish is then complemented by a sesame crisp, introducing a unique fragrance of roasted nuts while enhancing the overall texture.



Resting on a beautiful Bernardaud Ecume plate is the next dish, showcasing tuna sashimi. Unlike the otoro fatty tuna commonly found on sushi omakase menus, the choice of a lean cut of tuna enhances the mouthfeel and allows the pure umami flavor of the tuna to shine through. The lean tuna is skillfully crafted into delicate ribbons, accompanied by mustard seeds, exotic Thai lime, and green apple strips. The green apple and Thai lime bring waves of bright acidity, magnifying the pristine umami, while the mustard seeds contribute subtle crunchiness and a fiery rich aroma. On the side of the plate sits a quenelle of raw tuna mousse, paired with judiciously dotted shishito pepper purée. Although all the ingredients contribute to the well-rounded flavor profile, the heart of the dish lies in the warm brown butter vinaigrette. The chef opts for slightly caramelized butter instead of traditional olive oil, introducing a well-rounded, suave texture and intrinsically French full-bodied rich aroma that compensate for the one-dimensional subtle delicacy of a sashimi dish.



What comes after a raw fish, is by its nature, a cooked fish! On the plate rests peacefully a delicate piece of poached sea bass in its most tender and buttery status. The cylinder flesh is showered with a rich creamy black truffle mousseline, paired with braised endive, and finally finished with hints of orange fragrance. The magical element in this dish is the braised endive. Cooked to a tenderness reminiscent of melting butter, the endive, through its transparent texture, oozes a subtle refreshing bitterness. The bitterness, in a positive way, adds a layer of complexity to the flavor profile. It also balances and stimulates the taste buds by enhancing their perception of the sweetness and umami of the sea bass.

With a little bit of surprise, a Comté cheese soufflé emerges. While one could expect a cheese-tasting or a sweet soufflé or even a combination of both — as once tasted at Oriole — to appear in the dessert session, it is truly a bold move to present such a dish in the middle of the savory courses. At the center of the bowl lays a piece of comté cheese soufflé, firm and extremely flavorful. I find myself confused as the soufflé does not puff rising at all, the whole is still condensed and resembles an overcooked egg flan. The soufflé is adorned with compressed and laminated honeynut squash confit and some spiced pecans. An ethereal foamy bath of champagne emulsion envelopes the medley, sublimating the whole with its mellowness and subtle hints of acidity.





For substituting one portion of the cheese soufflé, the chef presents us with the sole vegetarian savory on our journey. It is one of the most sophisticated vegetarian dishes I have ever seen, curated with meticulous care — three textures of eggplant with three shades of curry. For each combination, we have a lacquered eggplant confit on the bottom, topped with a scoop of creamy eggplant caviar, and then finished with one fried eggplant chip. The vegetable curry coulis consists of three types of curry — the green curry made with green pepper and cilantro, the yellow curry with its oriental kick of turmeric and daikon, and the red curry owes its hue to beets. The confit method not only enhances the heavenly tenderness of the eggplant but also preserves its shape and full flavor profile while infusing a rich, buttery aroma. Eggplant caviar— a delicately spiced eggplant purée originating from Russia— along with the crispy fried eggplant, adds nuanced layers of flavor and texture to the dish. Regarding the coulis sauces, while the three different curries might appear overwhelming, their common curry base blends numerous flavors, systematically bringing a rich and profound mixture of spice market and vegetable garden flavors to the eggplant.



Despite my years of dining experience, which have acquainted me with this precious ambrosia in both the French tradition and Spanish interpretation, I still cannot resist the temptation to indulge once more whenever I see a sweetbread dish on the menu. As the dish arrives at the counter, it visually sends shockwaves through me. The bright orange color is solid evidence of its deviation from tradition. Underscored by the sweetness of the carrot dressing and the sourness from the citrus confit, the roast veal sweetbread reveals a modern twist and a vivid Asian flavor profile that almost resembles the notorious orange chicken by Panda Express. The texture of the sweetbread, notwithstanding, shows a lack of skillfulness. The overcooking of such delicacy directly petrifies the sweetbread, shattering my anticipated praise for its creamy, tender, and succulent texture into a mere illusion.



In a straightforward presentation, today's main course takes the stage — a cut of medium-rare filet mignon accompanied by baby carrots, braised leeks, and cauliflower spiced with French curry Vadouvan. Drawing from prior experiences of heavenly tender beef cuts at the Shanghai and Macau venues, the filet per se falls short in comparison. While tender and skillfully cooked, its texture carries a rustic and unrefined quality, reminiscent of a typical American steakhouse. Additionally, the cutting appears uneven. Nevertheless, what compensates for the filet's shortcomings are the meticulously curated garnishes. Each component works in harmony, creating a well-rounded base that complements the beef. The dish is dressed, as expected, with classical beef jus, and in line with all main beef courses at Robuchon establishments worldwide, it is served with a bowl of classical Joël Robuchon mashed potatoes.



Who could resist a pineapple dessert in Miami? As we pace into the realm of sweets, the first dessert presented is a refreshing pineapple dessert centered on a medley of elderflower gelée, marinated pineapple, passion fruit, basil sorbet, and pineapple foam. The tropical elements shine brightly in this composition, with the vibrant and passionate pineapple taking center stage to showcase its distinctive flavors. Passionfruit then joins in, contributing a sharp tartness and bright tropical fruity notes that, in a similar yet altered way, create a harmonious tropical duet with the pineapple. The basil sorbet, with its refreshing yet sweet herbal fragrance, balances the overall composition, while the elderflower jelly adds a subtle floral aroma and a touch of sophistication with delicate flavors reminiscent of pear and apple. The sphere is further capped with a thin chip of crispy candied pineapple and adorned with streusels for contrasting textures and a more condensed flavor base.



Presented in the precious Bernardaud Je Te Mangerais Dans La Main plate by Prune Nourry & JR is one of Robuchon's timeless classical desserts created by his apprentice pastry chef Salvatore Martone. In contrast to the black and white plate, the black forest cake is camouflaged in the appearance of a vibrant red mushroom. This artistic creation features a mushroom stalk crafted from chantilly cream infused with Kirsch liquor and a mushroom cap made of cherry-flavored chocolate crèmeux. Sandwiched between the cap and the stalk is a delicate layer of Griottines cherry compote. To complete the presentation, the mushroom is nestled in a medley of streusel, shortbread, and crumbles, artfully replicating the varied textures of sandy and clayey soils found in the forest. The taste of this cake, unfortunately, is neither as delightful as I remembered from my previous experiences nor as appealing as its appearance suggests. A red mushroom as such in the wild may harbor a lethal dose of poison, and akin to its appearance, the black forest cake here comprises a lethal amount of sugar. The sweetness is intense, cutting through the throat like a knife.



There's a saying that dessert comes in a separate stomach, and that's absolutely true. Even though the climax of the entire meal has lasted for quite some time, our excitement endures, seemingly uplifted by the city's ambiance. Craving more sweetness, we opt to revisit another Monsieur Joel Robuchon's classic dessert, Le Chocolat Sensation. It seems to be a self-deprecating nod to traditional French cuisine, a playful disregard for the refined traditions. It's as if Robuchon himself cannot help but acknowledge that this dessert is a deviation from aristocracy. It is fabulous in its own right, akin to a deluxe version of a McDonald's McFlurry. At times, extreme joy does require the simple, humble, and familiar delight to evoke it.



Joy continues to pervade the air as a dainty mousse cake of strawberry and raspberry emerges, delighting us with its surprise. Seeking a moment of tranquility, a pot of jasmine tea proves to be the perfect choice. Accompanying this, a petite yuzu lime tart with meringue concludes the magnificent journey, finishing the magnificent journey with a final nod to classical and a faint hint of the unquenched citrusy vibrancy. All good things must come to an end. As the servers gracefully escorted us out, a parting gift emerges — a delightful orange pound cake, extending the mission to perpetuate the joy.

